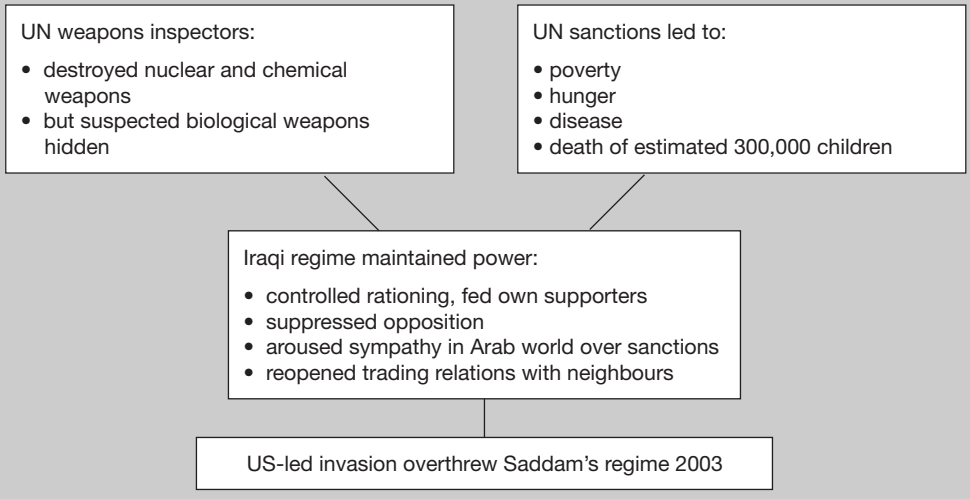
## Summary diagram: The UN, the USA and the invasion of Iraq 2003




**Key question**
Why did the occupation of Iraq descend into chaos?

## 3 | Occupation, Chaos and Reconstruction in Iraq 2003–8

The US forces put the oilfields under military guard and also took control of key government buildings. They also scoured the country for WMD, but none were ever found. Unfortunately, they had given little thought to how they would govern Iraq. After many years of repression and brutality under Saddam and further suffering caused by sanctions, the country now descended into chaos.

### Looting breaks out

In Baghdad poor people broke into government buildings having heard rumours of food stockpiled there. Then looting broke out on a massive scale: not just food stores but banks, hospitals, universities and the homes of leading members of the fallen government were ransacked. Similar scenes were enacted in other cities. There were little more than 150,000 coalition forces in a country of 26 million people. They were not prepared for the role of policing and they were not able to control the looting. Many Iraqi cities experienced a complete breakdown of law and order and, for millions of Iraqis, the quality of daily life deteriorated. Services such as water, sewage disposal and electricity, which had been poor during the sanctions regime under Saddam, became even worse. Ordinary Iraqis became angry with the occupying forces for not providing basic law and order. Meanwhile organised gangs took control of the looting and a resistance movement emerged.